

fourth highest civilian award in India, and five railway employees in Punjab were awarded the Shaurya Chakra (for gallantry other than in the face of the enemy).

Apart from aiding the evacuation of refugees, the railways helped Bangladesh repair four major bridges that had been destroyed by Pakistani forces, and supplied material for the restoration of damaged rail tracks.

THE WARS BETWEEN INDIA AND PAKISTAN

From its Independence in 1947, India's borders in the north and the north-east have experienced regular skirmishes. However, it has also seen three wars with Pakistan, one of which led to the formation of Bangladesh. The first, in 1947–48, started after armed tribesmen from Pakistan entered Kashmir. The Maharaja of Kashmir acceded to India in exchange for military assistance. A ceasefire was announced in January 1949. The second war began in 1965, after Pakistani troops and civilians crossed the border into Kashmir in a manoeuvre codenamed Operation Gibraltar. This started a 17-day war that ended with a UN-brokered ceasefire and the 1966 Tashkent agreement. The 1971 war began after Indian troops entered East Pakistan following the outbreak of a civil war, in support of the people there. The war came to an end in 1971 after East Pakistan became the independent nation of Bangladesh. Since then there have been several skirmishes along the Kashmir border, including the 1999 conflict in Kargil, Ladakh.

Peacetime endeavours

The TA has also been mobilized during civilian disruptions, such as the 1974 railway strike when they drove trains and fulfilled key roles to ensure smooth operations. It was renamed the Railway Engineers Regiment in 1977.

The present-day six regiments (in Kota, Chandigarh, Hyderabad, Jamalpur, Jhansi, and Adra) have railway personnel with a small nucleus of permanent staff drawn from the Indian Army. As a part of their role, they attend an annual training camp for compulsory arms, ammunition, and defence training.